The Second Sunday of Advent

Isaiah 40:1-11 * Psalm 85:1-2, 8-13
2 Peter 3:8-15a * Mark 1:1-8

Prayer

Gracious God,
as we journey through Advent, prepare our hearts for the coming of Jesus.
Like John the Baptist, help us to make room for Christ
by clearing away the distractions and obstacles that keep us from you.
Speak to us through your Word today.
Give us open hearts to hear your voice, courage to respond,
and a renewed desire to prepare the way for Christ
in our lives and in our world.
May this Advent be a season of expectation, repentance,
and hope as we draw closer to Jesus.
In his name we pray, Amen.

Opening

1. What are some of the ways we prepare for Christmas?

2. How does Mark introduce his entire book in verse 1, and what do the titles "Jesus Christ" and "Son of God" convey about who Jesus is?

3. How is John the Baptist described in terms of his appearance, location, and actions (vols. 4–6)? Why do you think people from all over Judea and Jerusalem flocked out to the desert to see him?

Engaging the Text

1. John’s ministry focused on repentance and the confession of sin (vv. 4–5). Why is admitting our sin a necessary first step in preparing our hearts for Jesus?

2. In verses 7–8, John humbles himself, stating he is not worthy even to untie Jesus' sandals, and contrasts water baptism with baptism in the Holy Spirit. What does John's attitude of humility teach us about our own position before Christ?

3. What does it mean practically for Jesus to baptize with the Holy Spirit compared to an outward ritual of water?

4. John’s primary role was to point people away from himself and toward Jesus. In what areas of your life or relationships is God calling you to be a "signpost" pointing others to Christ right now?

5. What does "preparing the way" look like in your daily routine this week? Are there habits, distractions, or unconfessed areas of your heart that you need to surrender to make room for Him?

Application Activity

The "Modern Messenger" Text

Give everyone 2 minutes of silence.

Challenge them to write a "modern-day text message announcement" about Jesus to someone who doesn't know Him well.

The catch: They cannot use religious jargon (like "repent," "gospel," or "righteousness"). They must explain who Jesus is and why He matters using everyday language, just as John translated ancient prophecy into an immediate, urgent message.

Have a few people read their texts out loud.